

in Tokyo. But she has unfinished business first. Mirabai will compete in the 48kg category at both the upcoming Asian Championships and Commonwealth Games. She has already won two gold medals in this category at the latter (2018, 2022) and wants to sign off with another.

"The Commonwealth Games will be my last competition in the 48kg category. I want to leave this category by doing something special. I think I am in good shape for this. Last year, after the Olympic weight categories were changed, I had to move down to the 48kg class. In the new IWF categories, the 48kg class is the lightest, although it is not an Olympic category. But even after I started competing in this class, my performance is the same as in the 49kg category, and in some ways even better," she says.

"In my last competition, I want to do better than I've ever done at the Commonwealth Games. When I analyse my training, I think my performance is going really well. I already hold the Commonwealth record and will try to achieve even more."

She has a number in mind: a 90kg snatch and a 120kg clean and jerk.

#### **Increased confidence**

"I got a lot of confidence from the National Championships. I lifted 89kg in the snatch on my second attempt. Then I attempted 91kg in my third. I've never attempted anything above 90kg in training. So even though I didn't complete the lift, it gives me confidence to simply attempt that weight in competition. It's the same with the clean and jerk. I've never touched 120kg in training before attempting it in competition. Now I know what that weight feels like.

"I keep a diary of my lifts where I write that I can cross 90kg in the snatch and 120kg in the clean and jerk. I know I am getting close," she says.

At the 2025 World Championships DPR Korea's Kang Hyon-gyong had won gold with a combined lift of 214kg.

Mirabai's confidence, she says, comes not just from attempting the



biggest weights of her career but also from staying injury-free for much of the past couple of years.

"In my career, I've suffered a lot of injuries to my joints, wrists and shoulders. But I've been working on my technique, especially in the first and second pull of the snatch and how I receive the bar overhead. All this has helped me avoid injuries," she says.

Mirabai has another goal this year: a medal at the Asian Games. For all her accomplishments, she has never medalled at the continental event. Her closest finish was fourth at Hangzhou.

"I've never won a medal at the Asian Games. I've done everything else. This is the one medal I don't have. More than anything, that's my target this year," she says.

While the Asian Games may be seen as a stepping stone to the 2028 Olympics, Mirabai isn't looking that far ahead.

"As of now, I'm focused on the Asian Games. Only after that will I think about the Olympic weight category. Of course, I want to go to the Olympics, but I will see how my body responds at the Asian Games. If it adapts well to the new category, I will have more confidence," she says.